ADULT ATTENTION DEFICIT

More adults in India are reporting symptoms of ADHD, as busier schedules and increased screen time worsen a condition that may have gone undiagnosed in childhood, and the growing conversation around the disorder now helps them recognise the signs

By **SONALI ACHARJEE** / *Illustration by* NILANJAN DAS

At 32, Ira Devyani Sanyal, an HR consultant in Bengaluru, prided herself on her love for precision. But then the lapses began: missed follow-ups, half-written emails, meetings she chaired but struggled to track. "I used to be like this as a child," says Ira. "My teachers called it carelessness. But I thought I had outgrown it." A workplace counselling session revealed otherwise. As she described her routines to the therapist, she prescribed a formal evaluation. The diagnosis put a name to her struggles of the past decade: ADHD, or attention-deficit/ hyperactivity disorder, a neurodevelopmental condition that affects attention regulation, impulse control and executive functioning.

India is seeing a rise in ADHD diagnoses among adults aged 18 and above. A 2024 study published in the journal *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology* examined 1,665 young adults aged 18–25 in Delhi-NCR and found that 14 per cent screened positive for ADHD symptoms. A broader review within the same paper placed adult prevalence in India between 5.48 per cent and 25.7 per cent. Clinicians at AIIMS Delhi's psychiatry OPD report a noticeable rise in young adults aged 20–27 presenting with attention-related concerns. It is the same at Mindscape, a mental health clinic in New Delhi run by psychologist Upasana Chaddha, where the waiting room is increasingly filled with young adults—many of them college students or early professionals—coming in for ADHD evaluations.

Most adults diagnosed with ADHD believe their condition has appeared in adulthood. But, as Dr Chaddha points out, "ADHD does not start in adulthood. Symptoms are present earlier but not recognised. Now, with better awareness and diagnostic tools, more young adults are coming in to get evaluated." India is now beginning to study and measure adult ADHD more systematically than before. Such research, according to a 2025 review in a SAGE journal, is increasingly focused on prevalence and clinical patterns. "Earlier, we were very alert to attention issues in children, but we did not extend the same vigilance to colleges or workplaces," says Dr Harish Shetty, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist. "There was an assumption that if ADHD existed, it would have been picked up in childhood." However, ADHD does not always manifest into overt hyperactivity—its most recognisable symptom—during childhood. It can also appear as forgetfulness, incomplete tasks, poor organisation or "careless mistakes", behaviours often dismissed as personality traits or lack of discipline. In quieter children, especially those who manage well academically, these signs are easy to miss.

The outcome is, as Dr Samir Parikh, chairperson of mental health and behavioural sciences at Fortis Healthcare, says, "We somehow end up staying be-



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DR UPASANA CHADDHA
Psychologist at Mindscape, a mental health clinic in New Delhi